When I met Rao in July 1993, my message was simple, ‘I am in line to take over as LPSC director after Muthunayagam leaves. Spell out the succession plan, or I quit.’

Rao sought to buy time. He said he was not seeking an extension, but I knew he would not have said no if the government offered him one. However, he said, his retirement was due only the next year, and that I should focus on PSLV.

‘Let’s launch PSLV first, we will talk about this later,’ he said.

I agreed.

We launched the first PSLV carrying the Indian Remote Sensing Satellite IRS-1E from Sriharikota on 20 September 1993. The first and the second stages performed well, but the launch was a failure because of the malfunctioning of the third stage.

Though the PSLV was a failure the success of the Vikas engine was special to me in another way. It was the first time the bell-shaped nozzle was being tested. In fact, when a committee debated whether an untested piece can be flown, I had successfully argued that the first flight of the rocket be considered as the high-altitude test for the nozzle since we did not have such a test facility on ground. This was a personal triumph of sorts.

Still there was no clarity on LPSC succession. I went back to Rao with my resignation letter. It was 8 November 1993.

I explained to him that my career path was not clear, that I could not hang around in uncertainty. By now Rao must have been clear that he would not get a further extension as the chairman once his tenure ends in April 1994. The proud man that he was, he would neither ask the government for one. I understood that Rao was also making moves to anoint his successor, who turned out to be Kasturirangan.

The ISRO chairman is nominated by a search committee and approved by the Indian Prime Minister, but often the outgoing chairman’s word was the unwritten rule. The only chairman not recommended by the outgoing chairman was probably Satish Dhawan, and this was because of Sarabhai’s untimely death on 30 December 1971.